



Brazil Trip Itinerary

Rio de Janeiro & São Paulo · December · 14 Days / 13 Nights

Budget-friendly summer travel plan

When	December (Brazilian summer — hot, 25–35 °C, occasional rain)
Length	14 days / 13 nights
Cities	Rio de Janeiro (9 nights) + São Paulo (4 nights)
Style	Budget — hostels, street food, free sights, public transit
Big moment	Réveillon (New Year's Eve) on Copacabana, if dates cover 31 Dec

One activity to confirm 🧑‍🤝‍🧑 — your request mentioned "familiar videos" and wanting to "do one of those." I've read that as **Favela Vidigal** (the famous Rio favela with epic viewpoints, the Dois Irmãos hike, and rooftop parties you see in travel videos), built into Day 5. If you meant **hang gliding over Rio**, a **baile funk party**, or a **guided favela tour** instead, just say and I'll swap it.

💰 Estimated Budget (per person)

All costs in South African Rand (ZAR). Converted at approx. **R18.50 / US\$1** — actual rate will vary. Excludes international airfare.

Category	Budget approach	Est. (14 days)
Lodging	Hostel dorms / cheap guesthouses (~R400–650/night)	R5,600 – 8,300
Food	Por-quilo lunches, street food, self-catering	R3,700 – 5,600
Local transport	Metro, buses, occasional rideshare	R1,100 – 1,850
Rio ⇄ São Paulo	Domestic flight (~1h) booked early, or overnight bus	R950 – 2,200
Activities	Mostly free sights + a few paid (Sugarloaf, Christ, tours)	R2,200 – 3,700
Approx. total (excl. international flights)		R13,900 – 21,300

International flights (SA → Brazil): your biggest single cost — roughly **R14,000–22,000** return from Johannesburg or Cape Town in December (peak). Book 2–3 months ahead.

Money-savers: fly Rio↔SP on GOL / LATAM / Azul booked early; eat your main meal at a *por-quilo* (pay-by-weight) buffet at lunch; buy a rechargeable transit card in each city; most of Rio's best things — beaches, hikes, viewpoints, sunsets — are free.



Part 1 — Rio de Janeiro (Days 1–9)

Where to stay: Copacabana or Ipanema for first-timers (safe, walkable, on the metro), or Lapa/Santa Teresa for a cheaper, artsier vibe.

Day 1 — Arrival & Copacabana

- Land, check in, recover
- Sunset stroll on Copacabana Beach; dinner at a *boteco* (casual bar)
- Easy first night to get your bearings

Day 2 — Ipanema & Beach Day

- Ipanema Beach — grab a spot, rent a chair, watch the scene
- Walk to Arpoador rock for the famous sunset (free, iconic)
- Cheap eats: por-quilo lunch, then street snacks (*pão de queijo*, *açaí*)

Day 3 — Christ the Redeemer & Santa Teresa

- Morning: Cristo Redentor via van or the Corcovado train (book ahead)
- Afternoon: wander Santa Teresa (hilly artist neighborhood, tram, murals)
- Selarón Steps (Escadaria Selarón) on the way down — free and photogenic

Day 4 — Sugarloaf & Botafogo

- Sugarloaf Mountain (Pão de Açúcar) cable car — go late for sunset over the bay
- Budget option: hike the free trail up Morro da Urca (first hill)
- Evening in Botafogo — lively, affordable food scene

Day 5 — Vidigal (the "video" highlight) 📹

- Favela Vidigal: guided experience or moto-taxi up to the top
- Hike Dois Irmãos (Two Brothers) for arguably Rio's best panorama
- Sunset drink at a Vidigal rooftop bar overlooking the coast
- *Go with a reputable local / community-run guide — the safe, respectful way in.*

Day 6 — Lapa & Nightlife

- Daytime: Lapa Arches (Arcos da Lapa); browse the Feira do Rio Antigo if on
- Night: Lapa street party — samba clubs, live music, cheap caipirinhas
- Rio's budget night-out capital

Day 7 — Tijuca Forest / Slow Day

- Tijuca National Park — waterfalls and jungle trails inside the city (free)
- Or a lazy beach recovery day
- Optional: Maracanã stadium tour for football fans

Day 8 — Islands / Day Trip

- Ferry to Ilha de Paquetá (cheap, car-free island), or
- Beach-hop to Prainha / Grumari — wilder, quieter beaches

Day 9 — Réveillon or Rio Wrap-Up

- If dates hit 31 Dec: Réveillon on Copacabana — wear white, 2M+ people, midnight fireworks over the sea (free to attend)
- Otherwise: last beach morning, souvenir shopping, farewell dinner

Travel Day — Rio → São Paulo

- Flight ~1h (SDU/GIG → CGH/GRU); cheapest booked ahead
- Budget alt: overnight bus (~6h) saves a night's lodging

Part 2 — São Paulo (Days 10–13)

Where to stay: Vila Madalena (nightlife/art), Pinheiros (food, central), or near Paulista Ave (transit hub). SP is huge — stay near a metro line.

Day 10 — Paulista & Centro

- Walk Avenida Paulista (car-free on Sundays — great vibe)
- MASP art museum (free on select days / cheap)
- Mercadoão (Municipal Market) — split a giant mortadella sandwich

Day 11 — Street Art & Parks

- Beco do Batman (Batman Alley) — free open-air graffiti gallery
- Ibirapuera Park — SP's Central Park; free museums, great for a picnic
- Evening: Vila Madalena bars

Day 12 — Food & Markets

- Liberdade (Japantown) for cheap eats
- Mercado Municipal or a *feira livre* street market
- Optional: football at Allianz Parque / Morumbi

Day 13 — Flexible Day

- Day trip: Santos (beach city, ~1h bus) or Embu das Artes (crafts town)
- Or slow city day: coffee culture, thrift shops in Pinheiros, rooftop sunset

Day 14 — Departure

- Last coffee and *pastel de feira*, then head to the airport
- Fly home (GRU is the main international hub)

Practical Notes

- **Documents:** South African passport holders currently need a visa/eVisa for Brazil — check and apply early.
- **Money:** carry some cash (Brazilian real); cards widely accepted. Tell your bank you're travelling.
- **Safety:** in Rio, don't flash phones/jewelry on the street or beach; use rideshare at night; leave valuables at the hostel.
- **Connectivity:** grab a local SIM (Vivo/Claro/TIM) or an eSIM on arrival.
- **Language:** Portuguese. A few phrases (*bom dia, obrigado/a, quanto custa?*) go a long way.
- **Sun:** December sun is intense — sunscreen, hat, water.

Pre-Trip Checklist

- ☐ Confirm exact travel dates (does the trip include 31 Dec for Réveillon?)
- ☐ Book international flights early (December = peak)
- ☐ Book Rio ⇌ SP flight or bus
- ☐ Reserve hostels/guesthouses (Réveillon week books out fast)
- ☐ Apply for Brazil visa; check passport validity
- ☐ Confirm the Vidigal activity (or swap for hang gliding / favela tour / baile funk)
- ☐ Travel insurance
- ☐ Notify bank / set up local eSIM

Costs and timings are approximate December-peak estimates meant to be customized. Currency converted at ~R18.50/US\$1; confirm current prices, hours, exchange rate, and safety guidance before you go.